

BASIC SIGHT-SINGING AND EAR TRAINING FOR CHURCH SINGERS

UNIT 7.2 - PITCH COUNTERPOINT AND HARMONY – BASIC CONCEPTS FOR THE CHURCH SINGER



COUNTERPOINT AND HARMONY (WHICH CAME FIRST?)

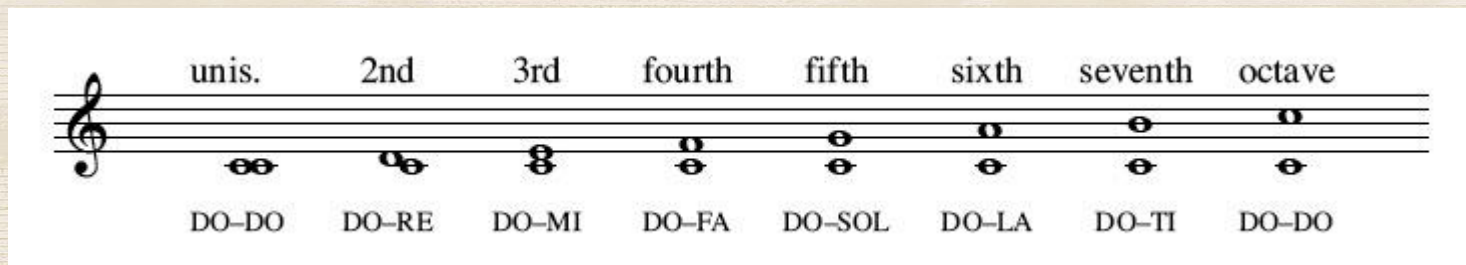
The art (and science) of **musical harmony** has a long history, going back nearly a thousand years. In its present-day form it is a fairly complex subject. For the purposes of this course, we shall consider only some of its most basic concepts.

In its most elementary form, harmony arose when singers discovered that two voices can sing **two different pitches** (and, by extension, two different melodies) **simultaneously** in time, thus forming vertical relationships between these two musical “events.” The art of combining two and more musical lines is called **counterpoint** (from the Latin *punctus contra-punctum*—“point against point”).

We have thus far studied only **horizontal relationships** between notes—one note after another, which we termed intervals. Counterpoint, and its corollary—harmony—is the study and awareness of **simultaneous vertical relationships** between musical notes.

MELODY AND ISON

The most basic form of counterpoint (and a primitive form of harmony) arises when a melody is sung over a **sustained drone** (*ison*). The intervals that sound simultaneously are the same ones that have been observed in melodies. Shown below are the intervals that occur when the notes of the C-major scale are sung over a sustained drone on C:



“ON-THE-SPOT EXERCISE”

Using the Virtual Piano Keyboard here: <https://virtualpiano.net/?instr=organ> (set to “Organ”), find middle C (here C5) by clicking Key Assist twice. As you sustain the C on the keyboard, sing up and down the C Major scale, using SOL-FA syllables. Listen to the intervals that you produce as your voice moves up and down against the sustained drone. (Men can use C4 as the drone note instead.)

Similarly, the intervals that arise when the notes of the A natural minor scale are sung over a sustained drone on A are as follows:

A musical staff with a treble clef and a key signature of one flat (B-flat). The staff is divided into eight measures, each representing an interval from a sustained drone on A. The intervals are labeled above the staff: unis., 2nd, 3rd, fourth, fifth, sixth, seventh, and octave. Below the staff, the corresponding solfège syllables are listed: LA-LA, LA-TI, LA-DO, LA-RE, LA-MI, LA-FA, LA-SOL, and LA-LA. The notes are represented by whole notes on the staff lines.

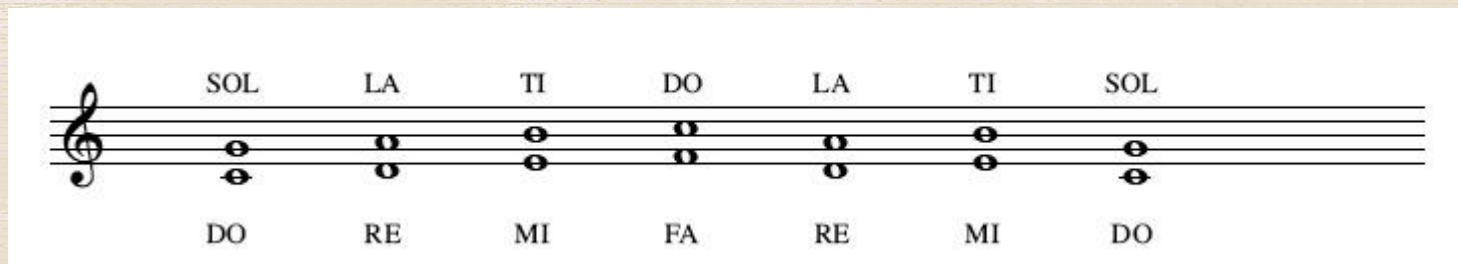
Interval	Solfège Syllable
unis.	LA-LA
2nd	LA-TI
3rd	LA-DO
fourth	LA-RE
fifth	LA-MI
sixth	LA-FA
seventh	LA-SOL
octave	LA-LA

Do the same exercise as on the previous slide, sustaining the note A on the keyboard and singing the intervals of the A natural minor scale, using SOL-FA syllables.

All the **qualities** of intervals that were described with respect to horizontal, melodic intervals are also true of vertical intervals. For, example, DO-MI is a major third, LA-DO is a minor third, DO-FA is a perfect fourth, LA-MI is a perfect fifth, and so forth. Refer to the table in Unit 4.1 (Slides 4 & 5) for a listing of the various intervals.

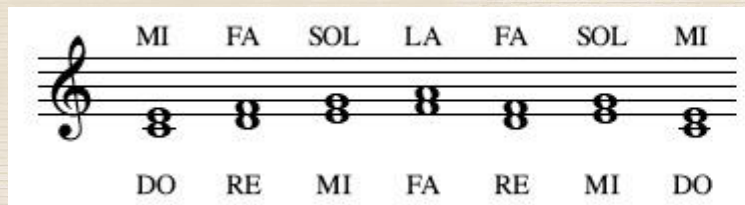
Just as in the case of horizontal (melodic) intervals, vertical intervals formed by two or more parts singing together retain their **quality** or **character** in various keys even though their SOL-FA syllable names change from key to key. For example, the interval formed by the notes F and A sounding together will always be major third, though in the keys of C Major/A minor it will be called FA-LA, while in the keys of F Major/D minor it will be called DO-MI.

When a melody is sung against a static, unchanging drone, each successive interval changes as the melody moves up or down. It is also possible for two voices to sing a melody at a distance of the **same** interval, resulting in what is called **parallel motion**. While it may sound exotic to our ears, the earliest examples of parallel motion, recorded in medieval manuscripts, were in **parallel fifths**:

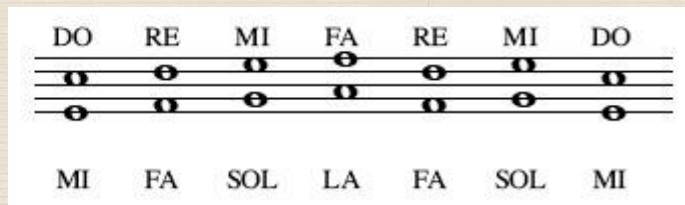


PARALLEL AND CONTRARY MELODIC MOTION

Far more common, especially in harmonized Orthodox church music (and a lot of folk music) is motion in **parallel thirds** or **sixths** (often employed in “spontaneous harmonizing”):



or



From a purely musical standpoint, the most “interesting” type of motion is **mixed**, combining both **parallel** and **contrary** motion. This type of melodic writing, which approaches genuine counterpoint, is rarely encountered in Orthodox church music, except in works by composers who possess a high degree of technical skill.



Please proceed to **PITCH EXERCISES 7.2**

